The diachrony of tone – HS 2026

Dr. Sandra Auderset

Tuesday 14:15-16:00, F004

This seminar explores diachronic aspects of tone, the use of pitch to distinguish meaning and grammatical categories. We will cover the emergence (tonogenesis), change, and loss (tonoexodus) of tone in tonal languages across the world. We will discuss methodological challenges tone poses for comparative linguistics, and how approaching these challenges advances linguistic methodology more broadly.

Syllabus – subject to change!

Session	Topic	Readings (for the respective class)
22.09.	Introduction: Tone, tone languages, and historical linguistics	(Yip 2002: chaps. 1 & 2; Gussenhoven 2004: chap. 3; Auderset, Dockum & Gehrmann 2025)
29.09.	Basics: Tone, intonation, and related concepts	
06.10.	Tonogenesis I: Haudricourt's analysis of Vietnamese and its legacy	(Haudricourt 1954; Haudricourt 2018; Gedney 1972; Hombert, Ohala & Ewan 1979; Thurgood 2002)
13.10.	Tonogenesis II: Typology and tendencies; Unresolved issues	(Michaud & Sands 2020; Sæbø, Grossman & Moran 2025; Brunelle & Kirby 2026)
20.10.	Tonoexodus: How tones get lost	(Ratliff 2015; Patin 2018; Downing 2019)
27.10.	The comparative method and tone reconstruction	(Dürr 1987; Beam de Azcona 2007; Hyman 2016a; Dockum 2019: chap. 5)
03.11.	Tone sandhi in a historical context	(Hollenbach 2003)
10.11.	Tone change *per se*	(Campbell 2021; Yang & Xu 2019; Yang, Pittayaporn & Kirby 2025)
17.11.	Grammatical tone and diachrony	(Hyman 2016b; Palancar, Amith & García 2016; Lovick & Tuttle 2024)
24.11.	Tonosyntax and its emergence	(Heath & McPherson 2013; Heath 2022)
01.12.	Evolutionary approaches and extra-linguistic factors in the development of tone	(Dediu 2011; Everett, Blasi & Roberts 2015; Everett, Blasi & Roberts 2016; Dediu 2021)
08.12.	Case study: Mixtec	(Dürr 1987; Auderset 2024)
15.12.	Open questions & future directions	tbd

Course logistics evaluation:

- readings are to be completed before the respective session and are an integral part of this seminar
- consistent attendance is not mandatory but highly recommended due to the interactive nature of the class
- by week 5 you need to decide whether you want to do 6 or 4 ECTS and sign up correctly in KSL; later switches are only possible for special circumstances

Evaluation:
6 ECTS

- 20% discussion lead (one session)
- 20% reading responses or wiki posts (6 total)
- 60% full term paper

4 ECTS

- 20% discussion lead (one session)
- 30% reading responses or wiki posts (9 total)
- 50% short report

The discussion lead prepares a short intro summarizing key points of the readings, prepares questions and moderates the discussion.

Reading responses and wiki posts should be posted on ILIAS before the respective class beginds. They contain min. 200 words each. Reading responses are not summaries of papers, but reflect your thoughts and questions. Wiki posts are overviews and summaries of key concepts in your own words.

The short report (4 ECTS, ~8 pages/min. 3'000 words) consists in an in-depth discussion of one or two of the sessions, elaborating on the class content and providing a critical reflection.

The full term paper (6 ECTS, ~10-15 pages/min. 5'000 words) consists in researching a topic of your choice related to tone diachrony. The class content should serve as a starting point, but the topic needs to be developed beyond that.

Use of AI:

The use of AI as a tool is permitted but not recommended and highly discouraged. You are solely responsible for the content of your coursework and the accuracy of content and citations. In this course, you are not permitted to include written or graphical output from AI in your assignments without editing and reviewing it.

For further reading: https://teachinghub.unibe.ch/journey_der_lehre/lehre_administrieren/pruefungsadministration/plagiat_und_plagiatspruefung/leitlinien_ki/index_ger.html

References

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